

Chinese dragons can take many forms. Some are familiar animals such as turtles and fish, but the most famous dragon in China is called the Long.



Many dragons have body parts from different animals, but the Long is unique in that it is made up of body parts from different animals, usually the ones shown here.

History of the Long

There are many stories about how the Long came to be, but it is most commonly thought that ancient Chinese tribes each had an animal totem or emblem. As these tribes came together their emblems were combined, creating the iconic Chinese dragon that we commonly see today.

Powers and traits

The Long rarely had breath powers such as fire breathing or gaseous poisoning, but it was usually able to control the weather and water. Longs are kind and wise, and bring good luck to those who deserved it. It is believed the Long are able to fly using magic contained in a lump on their heads called *chimu*.

The Long in culture

For a long time, only emperors were allowed to wear clothing with images of the Long.

You could tell how important a person was by the number of toes on their dragon designs—five toes for an emperor, four for princes and nobles.

The Long has become a symbol of unity, culture, wisdom, and strength, and it was featured on one of the first Chinese flags.